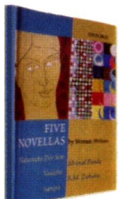


Savouring the Senses

Five well-known women let unusual stories unravel in many different tongues

By Geeta Doctor



FIVE NOVELLAS BY WOMEN WRITERS
by NABANEETA DEV SEN,
MRINAL PANDE,
VAIDEHI, B.M. ZUHARA,
SANIYA
Oxford University
Press
Price: Rs 595
Pages: 312

If you are like me and prefer to stab a carton of cold milk to open it, just plunge into this collection of stories. They are by five women who have let it rip, each in their own tongue. If on the other hand, you are the type who follows the rules, who likes to read the instructions and reach for the scissors, you might enjoy the long preamble, or should we say discourse, that introduces the five novellas. Uma Chakravarti even tells you what qualifies them as novellas, rather than say long short stories, or novels smitten with anorexia. The writers are well known: Nabaneeta Dev Sen in Bengali, Mrinal Pande in Hindi, Vaidehi in Kannada, B.M. Zuhara in Malayalam and Saniya in Marathi. It might be fortuitous that they appear together here in translation into English. As one of the translators, Nayana Kashyap, says about the Kannada writer Vaidehi's vivid memories of going to the temple fairs of her childhood in *Jatre*: "Is it a novel, a play, an essay, a poem...? It seemed none of these and yet all of these." The Kannada title suggests a journey, as against the more static "Temple Fairs" that is the English equivalent. If at all one can find a link between the five novellas, it would be to suggest that these are journeys of exploration undertaken by each of the writers (and their translators) that they unravel with a breath of honesty and precision that is totally engrossing.

There is often a suggestion that translations carry with them a slight touch of formaldehyde. They are the province of anthropologists memorialising a way of life that presents itself in a sepia-tinted manner. For instance, in most stories, the main character turns out to be death.

It marks the passing of a way of life, but what a life it is! The sheer abundance of the electrifying life force of Sen's women as they live together in an old-age home is what characterises her vignettes. They are as sharp and strident as the dead and dying inmates of Muriel Spark's deliciously wicked novel *Memento Mori* and yet they are so different. They are wrapped in an exquisitely wrought Bengali sensibility, as distinct as one of their red-bordered finely woven saris.

Bringing colour to translations and delicately seeking the nuances of what makes us different has been the success of Mini Krishnan's mission as an editor first at Macmillan's, and now at Oxford University Press. She's managed a fan-

tastic menagerie of authors who speak and write in a multitude of tongues and managed to groom them into neat packages that appeal to the vernacular illiterates who prefer to eat the English of "Modern Bread" in plastic wrappers. If not anything, the glossaries of vernacular terms that appear at the end of each section demonstrates the variety of food preparations that add the zest to

the narratives. When Radhika, the deserted wife in Saniya's Marathi story, *Thereafter*, finds that she has to cope living by herself in an empty Mumbai apartment, she makes enough cups of tea for her male visitors to set the India Tea Board on fire. Pande's ageing matriarch revels in a cupboard filled with fruits, nuts and tonics. The Bengalis have their fish, Vaidehi's memories of Karnataka's temple fairs circle around the roasted gram seller, while in Zuhara's evocation of a Moplah household in north Malabar, one can almost smell the fragrance of freshly ground coconuts, the hacking open of a jackfruit and the slithering shoals of freshly caught fish. ■

